Cecilia Y. Sui

Department of Political Science, Washington University in St. Louis · 1 Brookings Drive, St. Louis, MO 63130
c.sui@wustl.edu | ceciliaysui.com
Last updated: September 2026

Education

Washington University in St. Louis, St. Louis, MO
Ph.D. in Political Science — expected May 2027
Committee: Jacob Montgomery (Co-Chair), Christopher Lucas (Co-Chair), Taylor Carlson, and Ted Enamorado
M.A. in Political Science — 2025

Lipscomb University, Nashville, TN
B.S. in Computer Science, minor in Political Science *(summa cum laude)* — 2020

Publications

[1] Cecilia Y. Sui. "High Accuracy with Low Costs: The Pretrain-Finetune Paradigm for Classification with Transformer-Based Language Models." *Political Science Research and Methods*, 2026. [Paper]

Working Papers

Job Market Paper

[1] Cecilia Y. Sui. "Should Candidates Campaign Like Influencers? Evidence From 16,572 Instagram Reels and Two Generative AI Video Experiments." [Paper]

[2] Cecilia Y. Sui, Soyeon Jeon, Christopher Lucas, Jacob Montgomery, and Margit Tavits. "One Language is Enough: Using Transfer Learning to Detect Populist Rhetoric Across 25 Languages Without Translation." Draft available upon request.
Research supported by NSF Award #2215008 and Carnegie Corporation of New York Grant #G-23-60440.

Work in Progress

[1] Cecilia Y. Sui. "Seeing Inside the Black Box: Feature Attribution for Political Text in the Age of Language Models."

[2] Cecilia Y. Sui and Annie Jarman. "Gendered Costs of Influencer-Style Political Communication." *(Co-first authors).*

Grants & Awards

Awards

Antoinette Dames Prize for Best Graduate-Level Paper | WashU | $3,000 — 2023

External Research Support

National Science Foundation Award #2215008 | $571,005 — 2022–2024
"Populist Rhetoric on Social Media and Its Effects on Democracies"
PIs: Jacob Montgomery, Christopher Lucas, and Margit Tavits.
Supports the first-authored paper "One Language is Enough: Using Transfer Learning to Detect Populist Rhetoric Across 25 Languages Without Translation."

Carnegie Corporation of New York Grant #G-23-60440 | $330,000 — 2023–2025
"The Role of International Cooperation in Combating the Populist Threat to Democracies"
PIs: Jacob Montgomery, Christopher Lucas, and Margit Tavits.
Supports the first-authored paper "One Language is Enough: Using Transfer Learning to Detect Populist Rhetoric Across 25 Languages Without Translation."

Google Cloud Research Grant | $1,000 — 2025

Internal Research Grants

Weidenbaum Center Research Grant on Non-Textual Political Communication, with Jacob Montgomery and Christopher Lucas | $9,365 — 2026
Political Science Department Dissertation Seed Grant | $600 — 2026
Dissertation Research Grant | $1,000 — 2025
LSQ Research Grant | $5,000 — 2023

Travel Grants

Political Science Department Travel Grant | $700	2026
Political Science Department Travel Grant | $900	2025
Political Science Department Travel Grant | $900	2023
PolMeth NSF Summer Travel Grant | $900	2023
MPSA Travel Grant | $500	2023

Conferences & Talks

Invited Talk

Peking University (PKU Analytics Lab for Global Risk Politics)	2023

Conference Presentations

Midwest Association for Public Opinion Research — paper (scheduled)	2026
American Political Science Association Annual Meeting — paper	2025, 2026
Annual Conference of the Society for Political Methodology *2023 poster · 2025 paper · 2026 poster*	2023, 2025, 2026
Midwest Political Science Association Conference — paper	2022, 2023, 2026

Teaching Experience

Independent Instructor

Introduction to Python (Graduate)	Summer 2023
Introduction to R Programming (Graduate)	Winter 2022

Assistant Instructor

Quantitative Political Methodology (Undergraduate; Ted Enamorado)	Spring 2023
Quantitative Political Methodology II (Graduate; Jacob Montgomery)	Fall 2022
Introduction to Python (Graduate; Annamaria Prati)	Summer 2022
Quantitative Political Methodology I (Graduate; Ted Enamorado)	Spring 2022
Mathematical Modeling (Graduate; Ted Enamorado)	Fall 2021

Research Experience

Research Assistant | Jacob Montgomery and Christopher Lucas, WashU	2023–2024
Research Assistant | Taylor Carlson and Carly Wayne, WashU	2021–2022

Service

Journal Reviewer: *Political Science Research and Methods*; *Sociological Methods & Research*

Moderator, PolMeth ListServ	2023–2024
Department Graduate Student Mentor	2023

Skills

Languages: Mandarin Chinese, English
Programming: R, Python, HTML/CSS, Java, C, SQL, LaTeX
APIs & Tools: Twitter, TikTok, Meta Content Library, OpenAI, Claude Code, Azure, Amazon Mechanical Turk, Hugging Face, Upwork, Qualtrics, Prolific

References

Jacob Montgomery
Professor of Political Science
Washington University in St. Louis
jacob.montgomery@wustl.edu

Christopher Lucas
Associate Professor of Political Science
Washington University in St. Louis
christopher.lucas@wustl.edu

Taylor Carlson
Associate Professor of Political Science
Director of Graduate Studies
Washington University in St. Louis
tncarlson@wustl.edu

Ted Enamorado
Associate Professor of Political Science
Washington University in St. Louis
ted@wustl.edu